The skin was blue. I worried the baby wasn't getting enough air. Is she choking? I looked at Meg. *One more push, my love! We're so close.*

Here, here, here, the doctor said, guiding my hands, *right here*.

A scream, then a moment of pure liquid silence. It wasn't, as sometimes happens, that past and future were suddenly one. It was that the past didn't matter, and the future didn't exist. There was only this intense present, and then the doctor turned to me and shouted: *Now!*

I slid my hands under the tiny back and neck. Gently, but firmly, as I'd seen in films, I pulled our precious daughter from that world into this, and cradled her just a moment, trying to smile at her, to see her, but honestly, I couldn't see anything. I wanted to say: Hello. I wanted to say: Where have you come from? I wanted to say: Is it better there? Is it peaceful? Are you frightened?

Don't be, don't be, all will be well.

I'll keep you safe.

I surrendered her to Meg. Skin to skin, the nurse said.

Later, after we'd brought her home, after we'd settled into all the new rhythms of a family of four, Meg and I were skin to skin and she said: *I've never been more in love with you than in that moment.*

Really?

Really.

She jotted some thoughts in a kind of journal. Which she shared.

I read them as a love poem.

I read them as a testament, a renewal of our vows.

I read them as a citation, a remembrance, a proclamation.

I read them as a decree.

She said: *That was everything.*

She said: *That is a man.*

My love. She said: *That is not a Spare.*